

Sheeba Nair, Walter Noronha and Melwyn D'Costa among others, united by a cause that goes deeper than just celebrating the country's independence. Export manager Ravi Nair, 31, says, "For activism, you need passion." As the Andheri K-East ward coordinator for AGNI, a non-political, non-sectarian voluntary movement for good governance, he should know. The ward is not only the biggest but also the most active one in Mumbai, holding discussions on topics ranging from concretising roads and activating water connections to removing drainage blocks and illegal hoardings.

Presiding over this motley group is John, 38, a former naval officer and handball player. "When I joined the Indian Navy in 1988, Mumbai was a different city—we had playgrounds and footpaths. When I returned to the city in 2002, the footpaths had disappeared and open spaces had been

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RAVI NAIR

encroached upon," he says. Letters of protest gave way to activism as he became a member of AGNI K-East Jaag and co-founded the Active Alert Citizen's Forum. Today, a dedicated group of nearly 25 members keeps track of the 15 area corporators' funds, and gets a number of things done, like clearing clogged sewage drains, installing water pipelines, preventing illegal tree-cutting and water theft. All with the help of RTI Act.

Meeting once a month, the group perseveres despite physical threats and attacks. They pool in to print a newsletter that has a column dedicated to the Act with explanatory case-studies. John and his band of K-ward activists are always at the forefront of civic benefit. "The administration knows that we will keep following up. You pinch and they will respond. The RTI Act has kept hope alive," asserts Nair. And AGNI has lit a fire.

■ **By Nandini Vaish**

Shielding the sun from her eyes, Nidhi Nath looks at the shiny glass building which stands out in sharp contrast to its relatively duller neighbours. Actually it's a 1,60,000 sq ft new mall—Mittal's Mega Mall which has come up in the dusty Haryana Urban Development

ISHAN TANKHA



Authority industrial area of Panipat. While it may be an eyesore

to many, the new mall has come as a boon to the residents of the city. The four-floor building not only houses restaurants like McDonald's and Moti Mahal, but also boasts of a Big Bazaar, Koutons and Bossini showroom. The icing on the cake is the multiplex.

MALL BOOM



Panipat | HARYANA

Moolah rouge

A gleaming new complex, with its seductive charms of movies and food, plugs a small town into the entertainment universe

12.8
MILLION SQ FT IS
THE AREA THAT
MALLS WILL COVER
IN B-LIST CITIES OF
THE COUNTRY BY
YEAR-END

MALL'S THE WAY: Mittal's Mega Mall in Panipat

Ever since it opened in February, it has been attracting visitors, not just from Panipat, but also from neighbouring areas like Karnal, Sonapat, Samalkha and Jind. Weekdays see 3,000-4,000 people, while the weekend rush goes up to nearly 8,000 people a day. However, while the footfalls are high, the conversion isn't.

Movies and eating out are far more popular than shopping for clothes. Some like 23-year-old Hijji just come to gawk at women while others like Nath now see no need to go to Delhi to watch the latest movies. "Not much happens in Panipat," she says. Now with the mall in vicinity, Panipat is entertainment enough.